

SOCIO-RELIGIOUS CONTEXT PACKET

American Literature | The New England Theocracy & Salem Context (1692)

1. Core Pillars of New England Puritanism

Concept	Historical & Theological Reality	Impact on Social Order
Union of Church & State	Civil governance was directly merged with Church doctrine. Magistrates were religious leaders, and political voting rights were strictly tied to church membership.	Dissent from church doctrine was legally classified as treason against the state, eliminating public space for secular non-conformity.
Covenant Theology	Puritans believed they entered a sacred contract with God to build a 'City Upon a Hill'—an exemplary pure Christian society.	Created intense communal anxiety: an individual's private moral failing was believed to invite collective divine punishment (famine, war, disease).
Predestination & Anxiety	Based on Calvinist doctrine, God pre-selected the 'Elect' before creation. Human virtue could not earn salvation.	Generated perpetual psychological tension, forcing citizens to constantly look for signs of grace in themselves and hidden sin in neighbors.

2. The 1692 Frontier Pressure Cooker

External Threats: In 1684, King Charles II revoked the Massachusetts charter, stripping Puritans of legal autonomy. By 1692, border conflicts with Native American tribes (King Philip's War aftermath), harsh winter conditions, and smallpox epidemics created an atmosphere of existential panic. To the Puritan mind, the dark, unmapped wilderness was the Devil's physical domain.

Internal Factions & Grudges: Salem Village was deeply divided between agrarian families (Putnams) fighting for traditional religious purity and commercial families (Porters/Nurses) connected to prosperous Salem Town. Boundary disputes, timber rights, and fights over minister salaries turned private resentments into ripe conditions for legal witch accusations.

3. Key Terminology Matrix

Term	Definition	Relevance to Salem Witch Trials
Theocracy	A system of government where religious leaders rule in the name of divine authority.	Enables the legal system to prosecute spiritual 'sins' (witchcraft) as capital criminal offenses.
Spectral Evidence	Legal testimony where a witness claims to see the invisible spirit ('specter') of the accused.	Impossible to refute or disprove logically, ensuring high conviction rates until outlawed in late 1692.
Mass Hysteria	The rapid, uncontrollable spread of anxiety, fear, and delusion through a community.	Transforms private fear and social repression into collective, irrational public action.

4. Primary Source & Historical Analysis Prompts

- 1. Structural Power:** How does a theocratic government remove the traditional checks and balances found in secular legal systems?

2. Social Repression: Arthur Miller noted that Salem offered no outlet for personal desires or rebellion. How did strict social rules fuel the young accusers' behavior in Act I of *The Crucible*?

3. Spectral Evidence: Why is reliance on "unseen evidence" catastrophic in any legal proceeding, both in 1692 and in modern contexts?